

TEMPLATE REPO

AI Design Harness

Write your design rules down once, so people and AI agents like Claude Code or Codex build from the same place.

github.com/sadakoa/ai-design-harness

WHY

Why it exists

Design rules usually live in people's heads. The harness writes them down as small files, plus three skills (saved instructions like `/design-builder`) and one check script that catches broken rules, so an AI agent can follow them.

Today

- ✗ One long doc mixes rules, values and one-off decisions
- ✗ Review comments are personal opinions, not written rules
- ✗ Lessons from reviews get lost in old chat threads

With the harness

- ✓ One question, one file
- ✓ Review findings cite a rule, or say it's just taste
- ✓ Lessons flow back into the design system

WHAT YOU GET

One proposal per screen

Research, about three clickable mockups, a recommendation and a spec on one HTML page. The agent then reviews its own pick against your rules. Your team still decides, and builds it.

Support

MT Mia Torres

Inbox

10 open requests. 2 high-priority requests have no assignee.

Open10

Unassigned5

Assigned to me2

Done today3

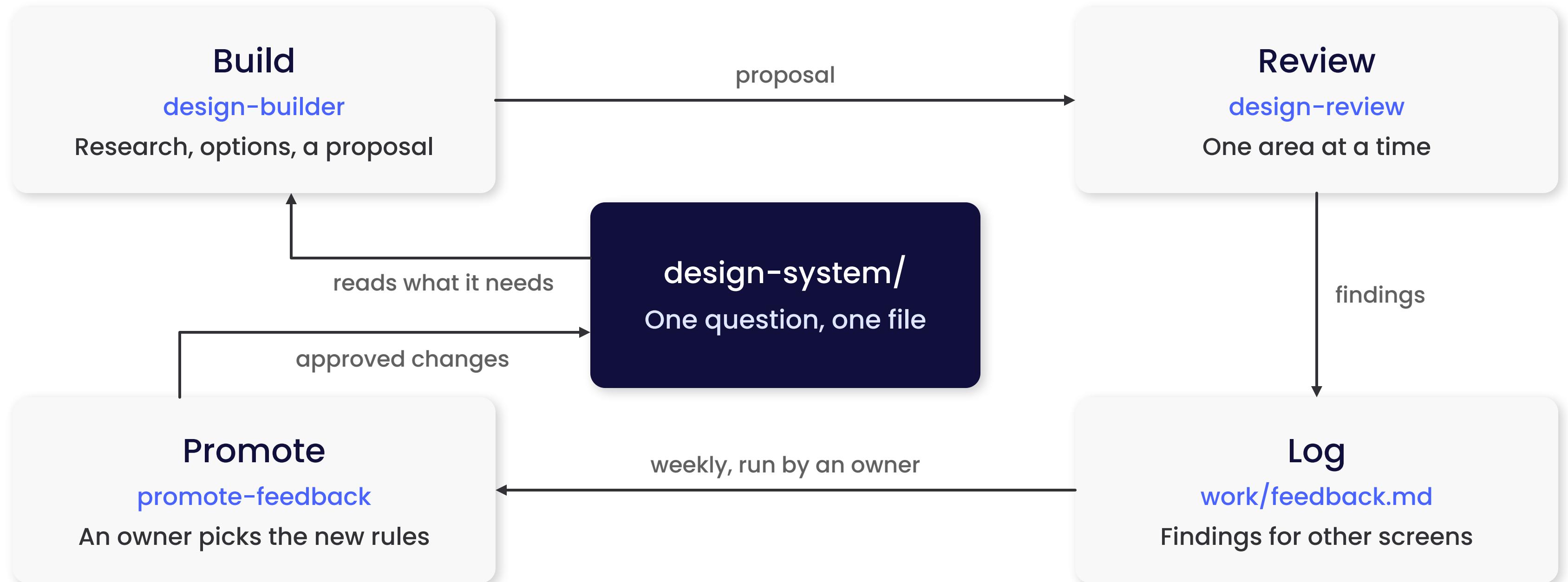
Sorted by priority, then longest waiting. Select several to assign them at once.

Search subject or customer

☐	Request	Status	Assignee	Received
☐	High 3			
☐	Bookings stopped syncing overnight Rafael Duarte · Copperleaf Hotels	In progress	DO Daniel Okafor	Oct 7, 2026, 8:05 AM
☐	Charged twice for the October invoice Amara Osei · Pinecrest Dental	New	Assign	Oct 7, 2026, 9:18 AM

HOW IT FLOWS

The loop



IDEA 1

One question, one file

INDEX.md — the map: which file answers what, and what to read for each task

Which exact values do we use?
tokens/tokens.json

Which CSS variables can I use?
tokens/tokens.css (generated)

What do we prioritize, and why?
foundations/principles.md

What must we never do?
foundations/rules.md

How do we write UI text?
foundations/writing.md

Which component should I use?
components/GUIDE.md

How does this component behave?
components/<name>.md

How do components make a screen?
patterns/GUIDE.md

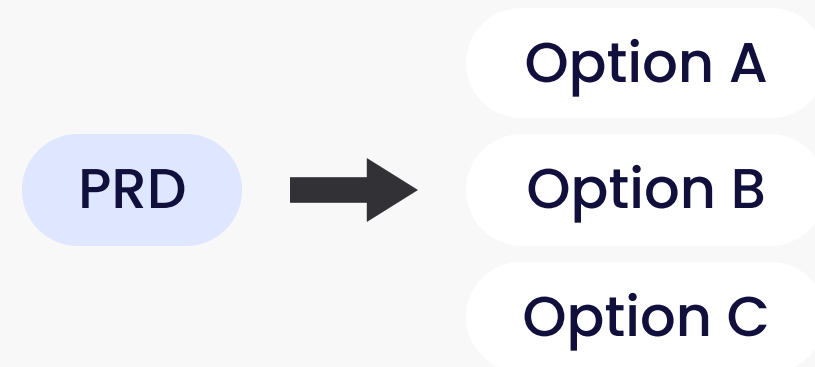
What do approved screens look like?
screens/

Why did we decide this?
decisions.md

IDEA 2

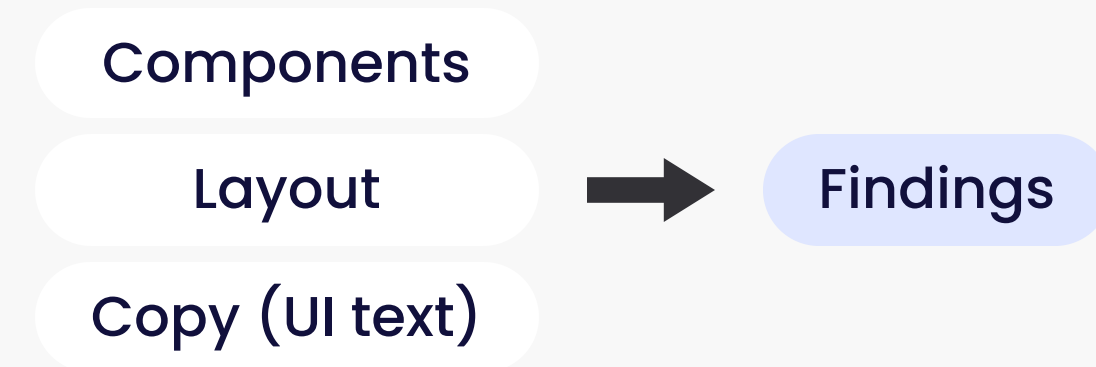
Build wide, review narrow

Build: explore options



Reads principles, rules, writing, layouts and approved screens, then builds options that differ in structure.

Review: one area at a time

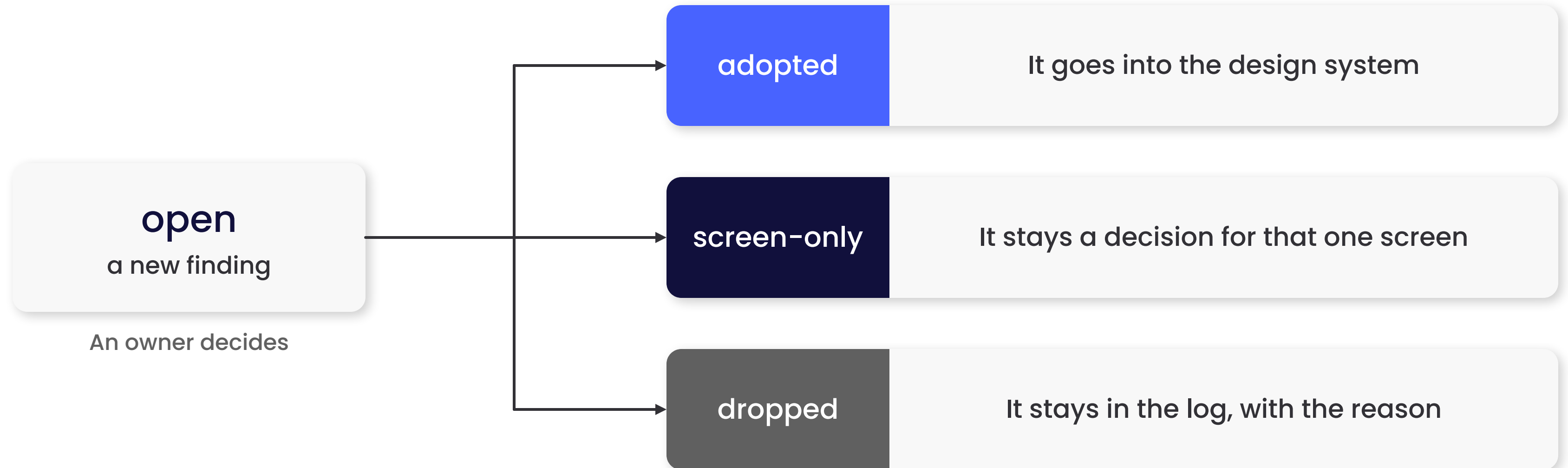


Each area re-reads only its own files. Every finding names its rule, or says it's taste.

IDEA 3

Feed reviews back

Promote a finding when it came up on two or more screens, or the same rule was broken twice — and you can name the one file where it belongs.



Running it as a team

Owners are the people listed in CODEOWNERS. They approve every change to the design system.

First months	Then	Every week	Approvals
Only owners change the design system. Collect findings first.	Designers open PRs too. Start with UI text rules (writing.md).	An owner runs promote-feedback and decides.	With two or more owners, require their approval on GitHub.
NOT FOR	Screens unlike anything your product has today. The agent drafts options; someone with design experience should finish them.		

START

Your first hour

For whoever sets it up. You need Claude Code or Codex, Node 20 or later, and git.

- 1 Use the repo as a template, or copy it into your product repo
- 2 Fill in the minimum: who it's for, your quality bar, your colors
- 3 Write a short PRD for one screen
- 4 Run /design-builder with your PRD (in Codex, ask for design-builder by name)
- 5 Open proposal.html in a browser

What's inside	
design-system/	Your rules, one file each
work/features/	Proposals and reviews
work/feedback.md	The feedback log
.claude/skills/	The three skills
scripts/	The check

NEXT

Let's try it on one screen

The screen	The repo	The owner	Questions
[Screen to try]	[URL]	[Name]	[Channel]

[Name] writes a short PRD and runs `/design-builder`. Then we look at the proposal together. Anything that could apply to other screens goes into the feedback log.

design-builder, step by step

01

Save the PRD

In a new feature folder

02

Define the problem

Whose task gets better,
and how

03

Ask you

Only what changes the
design (max 5)

04

Research

Approved screens first,
then others

05

Explore

About three clickable
mockups

06

Recommend

Pick one, tie it to a
principle

07

Write up

Everything on one HTML
page

08

Review

Run design-review, then
share it with you

Reading by task

• always · ○ when it's relevant · blank means skip. Review is split into components, layout and copy (UI text).

File	Build	Components	Layout	Copy	Promote
INDEX.md	•	•	•	•	•
tokens/tokens.css	•	•	○		
tokens/tokens.json					○
foundations/principles.md	•	•	•	○	•
foundations/rules.md	•	•	•	•	•
foundations/writing.md	•			•	○
components/GUIDE.md	○	•			○
components/<name>.md	○	○			○
patterns/GUIDE.md	•		•		○
screens/README.md	•		○		
decisions.md					•

What the check catches

`npm run check` runs on your machine and on every pull request.

File missing from INDEX

A file not in INDEX.md, or its Answers line doesn't match

tokens.css out of date

tokens.json changed but tokens.css wasn't rebuilt

Hard-coded colors

Raw colors in screens and options (R-01)

Unknown variables

CSS variables that aren't in tokens.css

Duplicate IDs

Two entries share an ID: P- principle, R- rule, D- decision, FB- feedback

Adopted without a decision

Feedback marked adopted with no row in decisions.md